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A Hamitic kingdom in the center of Africa

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II. Official Posts of Great Importance from the Standpoint of the Crown (Ingoma) as well as from that of the Executive. Generals and Official Drummers.

"Why don't you make the sky weep if you wish to find a remedy for your suffering!" people would shout at them as a joke (1). "If it does not rain at such-and-such a time, if you do not make our fields green again, you will die".... And execution followed close upon the threat.

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Like the king, the great Batutsi chiefs sat in judgment and passed sentence in their provinces when they resided there or whenever they were passing through. They were not all a like. Among them there were just and humane men, and one likes to believe that they were in the majority. Some nevertheless left a bad reputation on account of their cruelty. It is said that two of them took pleasure in having the arms of their victims bound behind their backs with wire drawn so tightly that the elbows met and the wire sank into the flesh.... Many persons died of this unique and atrocious torment. Another dignitary had those upon whom he wanted to wreak his revenge immobilized and made to lie on their backs.

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Then he would make his victim drink a pitcher of beer or water through a gourd shaped like a funnel. A third man, leaning heavily on his spear, would pierce his victim's foot and thus nail him to the ground. A high dignitary punished those who had displeased him by seizing two of their fingers and pulling them apart with all his might, thus tearing the tissues that connected them. Fortunately, however, those were exceptions which should be ascribed to paganism, the primitiveness of customs, the cruelty of the times, the

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criminal procedures then in effect, the passions aroused by clan struggles, the competition for power, the revolutions, and sometimes also the proud and savage conceit of chiefs who were too young to govern.³⁸⁰

Judicial Authority

In order to gain an accurate understanding of the more that prevailed at the time, the reader must be reminded that the life of a man counted for very little in the eyes of the king and of the great chiefs. Subjects of Lwabugiri who are still alive today (he died in 1895) report that in order to show his skill or to judge the strength of his bow, the sovereign would shoot at the first person who appeared  108 along the road, to the sanctimonious applause of his entourage. Once he even tried his spear against one of his chief lieutenants. The latter had the audacity to evade the blow, pick up the weapon, and hurl it back at him with equal skill. The king managed to duck and showed no displeasure, at least on that day. He even congratulated the man for his boldness and courage and said that he was a “man” (umugabo).

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Chief Executive

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Exploitation

1. Izuba libaririre!

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